

Why He Did It

Engelbart's aim was to make a computer user-friendly so that it could actually be used to improve life for human beings. The significance of the first public display of the pioneering features that constituted the NLS system is captured well in the phrase "Mother of all Demos". Engelbart had been developing on these features since 1963, when he was working for the Stanford Research Institute sponsored Augmentation Research Center.

The first computer mouse was a wooden box with two wheels below set perpendicular to each other (the mouse ball came later). It was patented under the title "X-Y Position Indicator for a Display System", and was named a "mouse" by Engelbart. The mouse was used to interact with the GUI called windows, which was the first time such a GUI was displayed. Since software patents were not being given, he could not patent his "windows".

The demo was also the first implementation of the Hypertext concept, by which documents that were linked were retrieved.

In the demo, Engelbart also held a videoconference with his associates at a different location. This was thanks to the network that had been set up by ARPA, which, too, funded his work.

The combined use of communication channels with hypertext and e-mail in the NLS makes it a precursor of groupware, a type of application that allows a group of people to collaborate on the same piece of data.

The demonstration, though spectacular, did not make any significant impact on the general public. Most of the features became publicly accessible long after 1968. For example, the mouse became popular when it was first bundled with the first Apple computer in 1980, and the hypertext-inspired World Wide Web became popular in the 1990s.